

Freedom



The signing of the US Declaration of Independence was symbolic of a widespread desire for freedom in the 18th century.

The political philosophy that developed from ideas of the social contract made frequent reference to the idea of freedom, but interpretations of this concept differed. Hobbes, for example, saw the unlimited freedom of a state of nature as an evil, and the surrender of freedom as necessary to civilized society. Locke, on the other hand, saw society as protecting the freedom of natural rights. Voltaire and the *encyclopédistes* believed in freedom from authoritarian rule, while Rousseau advocated freedom from society and convention, and Karl Marx later argued for freedom of the working class from exploitation (see [Das Kapital](#)). While the French and American

revolutions had 'Liberty' as their watchword, 19th-century British liberalism centred on John Stuart Mill's principle of freedom to do as we please, provided that does not interfere with others' freedom to do likewise. Like the notions of justice and virtue explored by Greek philosophers, freedom is difficult to define and a thorough examination of the concept only came with the 20th-century work of Isaiah Berlin (see [Two Concepts of Liberty](#)).